

Resource: Study Notes - Themes (Tyndale)

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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Study Notes - Themes (Tyndale)

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Salvation in Isaiah, Salvation in the Psalms, Security and Obedience, Seeking the Lord, Shechem, Sin Enters the World, Slavery, Social Chaos in Judges, Social Justice, Solomon's Wisdom, Speaking, Spirit Empowerment, Spiritual Maturity, Spiritual Renewal in the Later Prophets, Suffering in Following God, Symbolic Numbers

Salvation in Isaiah

The prophet Isaiah's name means *Yahweh is salvation*. He urges people to turn from false saviors to God who is the only true savior and protector. Salvation affects all parts of life, including physical and spiritual aspects. For example, the word *salvation* sometimes appears in the book of Isaiah with *righteousness* to show a peaceful order where injustice, disgrace, and mourning do not exist ([Isaiah 45:8](#); [51:8](#)).

Isaiah often shares the gospel (the good news about Jesus) that the Lord will come to help his people (for example, [4:2-6](#); [10:24-34](#); [40:9-11](#)). Although God promised punishment and exile because of the wrongdoing of the Israelites, the Lord would not abandon them. Instead, he would save them. Babylon's power and the suffering and shame of the exile would end. Chapters [1-39](#) prophesy this message, while chapters [40-66](#) explain it plainly.

Isaiah talks about the salvation God would bring through Jesus Christ. He prophesies "a Branch" from King David's family line who would have the Holy Spirit and bring justice and righteousness ([11:1-5](#)). He also mentions God's servant who would suffer for the people's sins ([52:13-53:12](#)). Jesus fulfilled Isaiah's prophecies and saved humanity from sin and death.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 27:1](#); [Isaiah 49:8](#); [Isaiah 59:15-21](#); [Isaiah 61:1-3](#); [Luke 4:18-21](#); [John 3:16-17](#); [John 12:47](#); [Romans 10:9-13](#); [2 Corinthians 5:18-21](#); [Titus 2:11-13](#); [Hebrews 9:27-28](#); [1 Peter 3:18-21](#); [Revelation 7:9-10](#)

Salvation in the Psalms

The writers of the psalms (called psalmists) considered God's salvation as a rescue from evil in the world. They had suffered a lot. During difficult times, they felt God had abandoned them. Meanwhile, evil people used this supposed injustice to mock godly people ([Psalm 3:2](#); [71:10-11](#)).

The psalmists called out for help, knowing they relied entirely on the Lord ([31:15](#); [35:17](#); [69:13](#)). While waiting for help, they trusted that the Lord was present, watching over them ([Psalms 46, 121](#)). He would not abandon them ([16:10](#); [94:14](#); see also [7:10](#); [31:2](#); [62:6-7](#); [144:2](#)).

God graciously rescues his needy servants and answers their prayers ([20:6](#); [28:8](#); [34:6, 18](#); [40:1-2](#); [76:9](#); [107](#); [145:19](#); [149:4](#)). When the Lord rescues his people, he gains glory when they thank, praise, and witness of him ([50:15](#); [79:9](#); [85:9](#)). The Bible records God's mighty acts. This is so that his people will praise him for what he has done and trust him to rescue them.

The psalms encourage Christians to relate to these stories of salvation. For example, in [Psalm 18](#), the psalmist talks about his distress, his cries, and the Lord's rescue ([18:17, 19, 20, 43, 48](#)). This invites all humble people to hope in the Lord (see [72:12](#)). The Lord has saved his people throughout history and will do so again.

Salvation does not include evil people ([69:27](#); [119:155](#)). Evil people mock those who trust in the Lord's rescue ([22:8](#)). Evil people might cry for help to the Lord during judgment, but he will not save them ([18:27](#); [50:22](#)). Hoping for God's salvation requires living by trust and love for the Lord ([119:123](#); [60:5](#); [108:6](#)). This kind of faith removes fear, knowing that the Lord acts righteously ([34:4](#); [71:2](#)).

The Lord Jesus came to save sinners. He helped those in need and on the edges of society. He provided physical relief to many. He died under oppression to bring spiritual freedom to the world. He saves people from themselves, from Satan, from death, and from difficulty.

He has the power to support the faithful, judge sinners, and fully save all of God's children. He will renew everything while excluding evil people from his eternal salvation.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 3:7-8](#); [6:4](#); [7:10](#); [14:7](#); [16:9-11](#); [17:7](#); [18:1-50](#); [20:6](#); [22:4-5](#); [25:4-14](#); [27:1](#); [31:1-2](#), [15-16](#); [32:1-5](#); [33:18-19](#); [34:6-7](#), [17-19](#); [40:16-17](#); [43:5](#); [46:1-11](#); [62:1-8](#); [70:4-5](#); [72:12-14](#); [80:1-19](#); [91:1-16](#); [98:1-3](#); [107:1-43](#); [121:1-8](#); [149:4](#)

Security and Obedience

The Book of Life is a divine record that contains the names of those who belong to God and will receive eternal life ([Revelation 20:12](#)). The idea of removing a name from the Book of Life may raise questions about whether salvation can be lost ([Revelation 3:5](#)). Does not the New Testament tell believers that their salvation is secure?

The New Testament offers many words of comfort (for example, [John 10:27-30](#); [1 Corinthians 10:13](#); [Hebrews 6:18-20](#)). But it also gives strong warnings (for example, [John 15:6](#); [1 Corinthians 10:6-12](#); [Hebrews 6:4-8](#); [Revelation 2:4-5](#); [3:11](#)). We often dislike and avoid these warnings because they make us feel less secure. Yet, this concern for security is exactly why the New Testament writers gave these warnings. They emphasized the need for obedience, faithfulness, and endurance.

This call to obedience was not new. God repeatedly called the people of Israel to be faithful (for example, [Genesis 12:1-2](#); [15:1-18](#); [22:16-18](#); [28:13-14](#); [1 Samuel 12:19-25](#); [15:10-11](#); [28:16-19](#); [2 Samuel 7:11-16](#); [1 Kings 9:4-9](#)). All of God's promises and prophecies depend on faithfulness and obedience (see especially [Jeremiah 18:7-10](#)). The apostle Paul understood that Israel's disobedience led to some being "broken off" from God's people ([Romans 11:17](#)). He warned non-Jewish (gentile) Christians not to be overconfident of their position ([Romans 11:13-32](#)). God's promise remains the same, but human disobedience leads to judgment. True security comes from humble obedience and reliance on God.

During New Testament times, being a Christian was difficult and dangerous. The book of Revelation offers hope for Christians, even when threatened by death. This hope comes with warnings about judgment ([Revelation 21:8](#), [27:22:15](#)). The call to faithfulness and obedience are major themes in Revelation (see [2:5](#), [10-11](#), [16-17](#), [26-29](#); [3:2](#), [12](#), [17-19](#), [21-22](#); [7:14](#); [13:9-10](#), [12](#); [16:15](#); [18:4](#); [20:12](#); [21:7](#); [22:3](#), [7](#), [11-12](#)). The New Testament affirms that with God's help, faithful Christians will persevere to the end (see [Hebrews 13:6](#); [James 1:25](#); [Revelation 3:10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 15:1](#), [13-16](#); [1 Samuel 12:22-25](#); [1 Kings 9:4-9](#); [Jeremiah 18:7-10](#); [John 10:27-30](#); [15:6](#); [Romans 11:13-32](#); [1 Corinthians 10:6-12](#); [Hebrews 6:4-8](#), [18-20](#); [13:6](#); [James 1:25](#); [Revelation 2:5](#), [10-11](#), [16-17](#); [3:5](#), [10-12](#); [18:4](#); [20:12](#); [21:7-8](#); [22:11-12](#)

Seeking the Lord

As Israel was about to enter the promised land, Moses instructed the people to "seek the place the LORD your God will choose from among all your tribes" ([Deuteronomy 12:5](#)). Moses told the Israelites to stop pagan worship practices and focus on worshipping God. In the wilderness, they built the tabernacle where God would show his presence and where the people would worship him. Once settled in the promised land, Moses told them to build a permanent holy place.

During the time of the judges, the people of Israel often worshipped the gods of nearby nations instead of the one true God. When the kingdom began, there was hope that the whole nation would unite in worshipping God. Yet, the first king, Saul, lost the kingdom and his life partly because "he consulted a medium for guidance" instead of the Lord ([1 Chronicles 10:13-14](#)). Many kings in Israel's history followed Saul's example of disobedience and led the nation into pagan religious practices.

King David, in contrast, was "a man after His own heart" ([1 Samuel 13:14](#)). As king, one of David's main goals was to restore the importance of the ark of the covenant. The Israelites had ignored it during Saul's time ([1 Chronicles 13:3](#)).

David failed in his first attempt to bring the ark to Jerusalem. This was because he and the Levites did not ask for the Lord's guidance on how to transport

it ([13:1-14](#); [15:13](#)). David later succeeded in bringing the ark to Jerusalem ([15:1-16:1](#)).

The holy place and worship in Jerusalem were essential for seeking the Lord. After placing the ark in its tent in Jerusalem, David created a new role for the Levites as music ministers ([1 Chronicles 16:4-6](#)). David often urged leaders to "seek the Lord your God" while building the temple ([22:19](#); compare [28:8-10](#)).

King Solomon's first action to strengthen the kingdom was to gather all the leaders at the altar in Gibeon to seek the Lord ([2 Chronicles 1:1-6](#)). The Lord met Solomon there and gave him unmatched wisdom and wealth. Later, Solomon finished the temple and established it as a place to seek the Lord ([2 Chronicles 6](#)).

Isaiah the prophet encouraged people waiting for God's promises to seek him. "Seek the LORD while He may be found; call on Him while He is near" ([Isaiah 55:6](#)). God's covenant and promise are certain, and they are for those who seek the Lord ([55:3](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Chronicles 10:13-14](#); [13:3](#); [16:11-13](#); [22:19](#); [28:8-10](#); [2 Chronicles 6:19-40](#); [7:14](#); [Psalms 27:4-8](#); [105:4-6](#); [Isaiah 55:6-7](#); [Jeremiah 29:13-14](#); [Matthew 6:31-33](#); [Romans 2:7](#)

Shechem

Shechem was in an important location at the entrance to the passage between Mount Ebal and Mount Gerizim. It could control several important roads through the central hill country. Jacob bought land near Shechem ([Genesis 33:18-19](#)).

While there, the local prince named Shechem raped Jacob's daughter, Dinah. In response, Dinah's brothers, Simeon and Levi, killed all the men in the area ([Genesis 34](#)). Later, Shechem became part of Joseph's inheritance ([Joshua 24:32](#)). It was also one of the special cities where people could go to find protection if they accidentally killed someone (see [Deuteronomy 19:1-13](#); [Joshua 20:7](#)).

During the time of the judges, Gideon's son Abimelech ruled from Shechem ([Judges 9](#)). King Solomon later strengthened Shechem as a provincial capital. But Shishak of Egypt probably destroyed it when he invaded Israel in 926 BC (see [1 Kings 14:25](#)). Jeroboam I then rebuilt the city and made it the capital of the kingdom of Israel ([1 Kings](#)

[12:25](#)). The Assyrian king Shalmaneser V destroyed Shechem again in 724 BC. This was shortly before Samaria's destruction. The ruins remained mostly uninhabited for about four hundred years.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 33:18-19](#); [Joshua 8:30-35](#); [20:7](#); [24:1-32](#); [Judges 9:1-56](#); [1 Kings 12:1, 25](#); [John 4:5](#)

Sin Enters the World

[Genesis 3](#) explains how humans lost their moral innocence by rebelling against God. What God called "very good" was no longer perfect ([Genesis 1:31](#)). The man and woman ate the fruit that promised knowledge of good and evil, disobeying God's command ([2:16-17](#)). They tried to become like God (see [3:5](#)). By doing this, they gave up their sinless state. They became separated from God, each other, and creation. They also experienced death.

As a result, all humans are "fallen," meaning they are born into a corrupt world that causes a tendency to sin ([Genesis 8:21](#); [Job 4:17-21](#); [Psalms 51:5](#); [103:10](#); [143:2](#); [Proverbs 20:9](#)). All humans also now experience death. When the first man and woman disobeyed God by eating the fruit, they lost their innocence. Their descendants and the entire human race now inherit a cursed world ([Romans 5:12-14](#); [1 Corinthians 15:21-22, 45-49](#)).

The term "original sin" describes how the effects of the first sin of Adam and Eve have spread into individual lives and society because of human rebellion. As people submit to their tendency to sin, they become accountable for their own actions ([Ecclesiastes 7:20](#); [Romans 3:23](#)).

The first man, Adam, brought sin into the world, but the "second Adam," Jesus Christ, is the solution to sin ([1 Corinthians 15:3](#); [2 Corinthians 5:21](#)). When Christ died as redeemer, he offered God's salvation from sin to everyone ([John 3:16](#); [Romans 1:16](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 3:1-19](#); [8:21](#); [Exodus 34:7](#); [Job 4:17-21](#); [Psalm 51:5](#); [Proverbs 22:15](#); [Ezekiel 36:16-36](#); [John 8:1-11](#); [Romans 1:18-3:20](#); [5:12-21](#); [1 Corinthians 15:21-22](#); [Galatians 3:22](#); [5:17-24](#); [Ephesians 2:1-10](#); [1 John 3:14](#)

Slavery

Slavery was common in the Roman world. Prisoners of war often became slaves, many were born into slavery, and some chose slavery temporarily to pay off debts. A large part of the population, including many Christians, were slaves or former slaves (see [Acts 6:9](#)). So, why did the apostle Paul not speak against slavery?

There are two reasons. First, slavery in the Roman world was different from the slavery familiar to the modern western world. It was not based on race and was rarely lifelong. Most slaves expected freedom by age thirty. Some people even sold themselves into slavery to increase social status. Some slaves were well-educated and held important roles in their households and society. Many had friendly relationships with their masters. In the Roman world, Christians like Philemon did not feel guilty about owning slaves.

Second, Paul did not oppose slavery because it was not his mission to change society's structures but to build the church. He wanted people to convert and transform spiritually. For Paul, whether a Christian is a slave or not is not very important, just like other external circumstances. The key is serving Jesus Christ, no matter one's life situation. In other words, Paul focused more on Christian life and witness than on physical freedom.

Even slaves can do their work as an act of worship ([Ephesians 6:5-8](#); [Colossians 3:22-24](#); compare [1 Timothy 6:1-2](#)). When Paul speaks to Christian slaves, he encourages them to see their situation as a calling where they can serve Christ. Christ is their true master, and in him, they are truly free ([1 Corinthians 7:20-24](#)).

Every Christian, whether slave or free, has been freed from the worst kind of slavery, slavery to sin. They can now experience true freedom by living as a servant of God and righteousness ([Romans 6:6-22](#)). For Paul, this is the only kind of slavery and freedom that truly matters.

Passages for Further Study

[Romans 6:6-22](#); [1 Corinthians 7:20-24](#); [9:19](#); [Ephesians 6:5-8](#); [Colossians 3:22-24](#); [1 Timothy 6:1-2](#); [Philemon 1:8-21](#)

Social Chaos in Judges

The book of Judges emphasizes divine rescue through heroes but also shows the problems of

their current situation. During this time, personal commitment to God decreased while social problems increased. This is especially true in chapter [5](#) (for example, [5:6-8](#)).

Three main issues stand out:

1. The tribes struggled to work together, even against a common enemy (see, for example, the stories of Gideon and Jephthah; chapters [8](#), [12](#)). The conflicts within each tribe and between different tribes show disobedience to the covenant.
2. The book shows the collapse of civil society. Abimelech kills Gideon's sons, Jephthah seems to sacrifice his daughter, and Samson seeks revenge against the Philistines. These acts emphasize the moral corruption and lack of social politeness during this time.
3. Abandoning the Jewish faith was common in those days. The Israelites often did "evil in the sight of the LORD," which linked to idol worship ([Judges 2:11-13](#); [3:7](#); [10:6](#)). The altar to Baal and the Asherah pole in Gideon's town of Ophrah show an obvious abandoning of the Lord ([6:25-30](#)). This is similar to the worship of the golden ephod made by Gideon and the return to worshipping Baal after Gideon's death ([8:27, 33-35](#)). Samson's marriage to a Philistine woman also went against the covenant commands (see [Deuteronomy 7:1-4](#)).

Social chaos peaks in the final chapters ([Judges 17-21](#)). The story of Micah, the Levite, and the Danites mixes religious problems with lawless raids, theft, and violence (chapters [17-18](#)). The intense final section tells of a tragic civil war and the complete loss of social politeness (chapters [19-21](#)).

Marital problems, lack of hospitality, rape, and murder almost wiped out the Benjamites (chapters [Judges 19](#) and [20](#)). They survived only because the Israelites destroyed a historic city, Jabesh-gilead. Then a fake ceremony allowed the Benjamites to take young virgins as wives ([21:6-23](#)). It is no surprise that the book ends with, "In those days

there was no king in Israel; everyone did what was right in his own eyes" ([21:25](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Judges 5:6-8; 6:25-27; 8:1-35; 12:1-15; 17:1-21:25; Psalms 11:2-7; Proverbs 28:2-3; Jeremiah 5:7-9; 12:1-17; Micah 3:9-12; 7:2-7; Romans 1:21-32; Galatians 5:19-23](#)

Social Justice

In the Old Testament, prophets often challenged evil in society and called for social justice (fair treatment of all people, especially the poor and vulnerable). An early example is the prophet Elijah's response to Naboth's murder and his rebuke of King Ahab ([1 Kings 21:16-24](#), 800s BC). The social focus of the prophetic message grew stronger among the prophets of the 700s BC. The prophets Hosea and Amos emphasized this social focus in Israel, and the prophets Micah and Isaiah in Judah. The prophet Amos was the most vocal about social justice.

Israel's bad treatment of the powerless shocked the prophet Amos ([Amos 2:6-8; 3:10](#)). Unlike nearby nations, Israel had a special relationship with God, but they abandoned him ([2:9-12; 3:1-2](#)). The people of Israel refused to worship God properly and oppressed the powerless, so God would judge them without mercy ([4:12](#)). God wants his people "to let justice roll on like a river" ([Amos 5:24](#)). Those who resist it will be swept away.

The New Testament emphasized the importance of social justice. Jesus linked true worship with practicing social justice. He warned about judgment for those who do not show their faith through loving actions (see [Matthew 25:31-46](#)). Understanding must link to action, proving one's faith (see [Luke 10:25-37; John 13:35](#)). The followers of Jesus understood that social justice was essential in early Christian communities (see [Acts 2:44-45; Galatians 2:9-10; 1 Timothy 5:3-16; James 1:27-2:26; 1 John 3:17-19](#)).

Scripture shows God's compassion for those who suffer. As followers of Jesus, we must help those in need. Like the prophets, we must stand against injustice wherever we find it.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 23:1-12; Leviticus 19:9-18; Deuteronomy 10:17-20; 16:18-20; 24:10-22; 1 Kings 21:1-24; 2](#)

[Chronicles 19:4-11; Psalms 94:20-23; 146:3-9; Proverbs 22:8-9; 31:8-9; Ecclesiastes 5:8-9; Isaiah 1:17; 5:7; 9:6-7; 10:1-2; 42:1-4; 58:4-12; Amos 2:6-8; 5:7-17, 23-24; Matthew 12:15-21; 23:23; Luke 10:25-37; Hebrews 1:8-9](#)

Solomon's Wisdom

When God gave King Solomon the chance to ask for anything, Solomon chose wisdom. He wanted to govern God's people well and know right from wrong ([1 Kings 3:9](#)). Because of this unselfish choice, God granted him the wisdom he wanted and the rewards of using it properly ([3:12, 13-14; 2 Chronicles 1:14-17](#)).

Solomon's actions quickly showed his wisdom. He solved a dispute over a child so wisely that it amazed the people ([1 Kings 3:16-28](#)). Later, the queen of Sheba visited to challenge him with difficult questions. She found his wisdom greater than she had heard ([10:1-9](#)).

Many things showed Solomon's wisdom, including:

- how he organized and managed his government and officials ([4:1-28](#));
- how he handled relationships with other nations and kings ([5:1-9](#));
- the structures he built, especially the temple and his palace ([5:10-7:51](#)); and
- his business dealings and trade with other nations ([9:26-28; 10:14-29](#)).

Solomon gained vast knowledge ([4:29-33](#)). He wrote proverbs (much of the book of Proverbs) as well as songs ([Psalms 72; 127](#)). He also wrote love poetry (see the Song of Songs) and philosophical works (see Ecclesiastes). He used his wisdom to build the temple ([2 Chronicles 2:12](#)). This was like Bezalel who had been given wisdom to build the tabernacle ([Exodus 31:1-3](#)).

Jesus emphasized Solomon's great wisdom and told his listeners that, "One greater than Solomon is here" ([Matthew 12:42](#)). Jesus is the true wisdom of God, where one can find ultimate wisdom ([1 Corinthians 1:24](#)). A wise life is centered in Jesus and in Scripture ([1 Corinthians 1:18-25; Colossians 3:16; 2 Peter 3:18; 2 Timothy 3:14-17](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 31:1-6](#); [1 Kings 3:5-14](#); [3:16-28](#); [4:29-34](#); [5:2-7](#); [10:1-13](#); [2 Chronicles 1:7-12](#); [Psalms 72:1-20](#); [111:10](#); [127:1-5](#); [Ecclesiastes 12:9-14](#); [Isaiah 11:1-5](#); [Jeremiah 9:23-24](#); [Matthew 12:42](#); [James 1:5](#)

Speaking

Some people think words do not cause harm. Scripture offers a different perspective. Words hold the power of "life and death" ([Proverbs 18:21](#)).

Proverbs lists many things we say that cause harm:

- lies ([Proverbs 14:5, 25](#))
- arguments ([Proverbs 26:17](#))
- insults or curses ([Proverbs 20:20](#))
- speaking falsely about someone to damage their reputation ([Proverbs 10:18](#))
- spreading private information about others or unverified stories passed from person to person ([Proverbs 11:13](#); [18:8](#))
- excessive or insincere praise given to manipulate someone ([Proverbs 7:21-22](#))
- speaking too proudly about oneself ([Proverbs 26:23](#); [27:2](#))

The book of Proverbs often emphasizes that foolish people say foolish things. "The woman named Folly" symbolizes these people ([9:13-18](#)). She lies and deceives to harm her listeners. Words show the heart's condition ([16:23](#); [18:4](#)).

Someone might hide an evil heart with pleasant words ([26:23](#)). But true character will eventually appear ([26:24-26](#)). Foolish words harm others and eventually hurt the speaker. The tongue is full of wickedness that can ruin your life ([James 3:6](#)).

In contrast, wise people speak words that give life, as shown by wisdom ([Proverbs 8:7-9](#); [10:11](#)). Wise people use their words carefully and are usually gentle ([17:27-28](#); [15:4](#); [16:24](#)). Yet, a wise person also knows the right time to speak ([15:23](#); [25:11](#)). This person understands that sometimes even harsh criticism is necessary (see [27:5](#)). The book of Proverbs wisely reminds readers to pay attention

not only to what they say but also to how and when they say it.

Passages for Further Study

[Proverbs 7:21-22](#); [8:7-9](#); [9:13-18](#); [10:11](#), [18](#); [11:13](#); [14:5](#), [25](#); [15:4](#), [23](#); [16:23-24](#); [17:28](#); [18:4](#), [21](#); [20:20](#); [25:11](#); [26:17](#), [23-26](#); [27:2](#), [5](#); [Matthew 12:33-37](#); [James 3:1-12](#)

Spirit Empowerment

Throughout the Bible, when needed, God gives special abilities to those committed to serving him. The story of Moses and the seventy elders is an early example. It shows that God has acted in special ways among his people throughout history. When Moses had no more patience for rebellious Israel, God instructed him to choose seventy men to assist him ([Numbers 11:1-15](#), [16-17](#); see also [Exodus 18:14-26](#)). Then, God shared the Holy Spirit that Moses had with these men, empowering them for service ([Numbers 11:24-25](#)).

God's Spirit-empowered Joshua to succeed Moses ([Numbers 27:18](#); see also [Deuteronomy 34:9](#)). During the time of the judges, the Spirit of God helped Israel's leaders. This included:

- Othniel ([Judges 3:10](#));
- Gideon ([Judges 6:34](#));
- Jephthah ([Judges 11:29](#)); and
- Samson ([Judges 13:25](#); [14:6](#), [19](#); [15:14](#)).

King David drew strength from God's presence. His understanding of God's actions in history and his life made him a great leader (for example, [1 Samuel 16:13](#); [17:45](#); [18:12](#), [28](#)). The prophets knew their special work was possible because of the Spirit's presence and power (for example, [Isaiah 61:1](#); [Ezekiel 11:5](#); [Zechariah 4:6](#)).

God's Spirit anointed Jesus and empowered for a special mission (see [Matthew 12:18](#); [Luke 4:1](#), [14](#), [18](#); [John 3:34](#); [Acts 10:38](#)). He spoke about the Spirit's important role in the church ([Acts 1:8](#)). The Spirit's arrival allowed the gathered Christians to speak with power on the day of Pentecost ([Acts 2:4-5](#), [16-18](#); compare [Joel 2:28-29](#)).

After Pentecost, the Spirit gave the church courage and strength ([Acts 4:31](#); [19:6](#); [20:28](#); [1 Corinthians 12:1-31](#); [Galatians 3:2-5](#)). The Holy Spirit still remains with God's people today. The Spirit acts as

needed to renew and strengthen God's people. He continues to prepare them for the tasks God calls them to do.

Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 11:16-30](#); [24:1-9](#); [27:18-23](#); [Deuteronomy 34:10-12](#); [Judges 3:9-10](#); [6:34](#); [11:29](#); [14:5-6](#), [19](#); [15:14](#); [1 Samuel 16:13](#); [Psalms 23](#); [46:1](#); [94:16-19](#); [116:1-9](#); [121:1-8](#); [143:10-12](#); [Isaiah 61:1](#); [Ezekiel 11:5](#); [Joel 2:28-29](#); [Zechariah 4:6](#); [Matthew 12:18](#); [Luke 4:1](#), [14](#), [18](#); [John 3:34](#); [Acts 1:8](#); [2:4](#), [16-18](#); [4:31](#); [10:38](#); [19:6](#); [20:28](#); [1 Corinthians 12:1-31](#); [Galatians 3:2-5](#)

Spiritual Maturity

When someone trusts in Jesus Christ for salvation, it marks the beginning of a journey that will continue the rest of their life. They do not stay the same. They transform and grow to be more like Jesus. This process is called "sanctification." Like newborn babies need milk to grow before they can eat solid food, new Christians need "pure spiritual milk" to fully experience salvation ([1 Peter 2:2-3](#)). Eventually, they will be ready for the "solid food" of deeper teachings ([Hebrews 5:11-14](#)).

Spiritual maturity involves the ability to understand spiritual wisdom ([1 Corinthians 2:6](#)). The apostle Paul commands Christians to think maturely ([1 Corinthians 14:20](#)). The body of Christ matures as Christians become spiritually equipped and learn about the Son of God ([Ephesians 4:11-16](#)). This leads to a united faith community where love and truth strengthen the body of Christ.

The audience of Hebrews was spiritually immature. The author wanted to provide them with substantial spiritual teachings. But they behaved like spiritual infants who needed basic nourishment instead of deeper lessons ([Hebrews 5:12](#)). They had not been attentive to God's teachings. They had been Christians long enough to teach others, but their growing insensitivity made them spiritually dull ([5:11-12](#); compare [1 Corinthians 3:1-3](#)).

They lacked the maturity to understand the basic difference between right and wrong ([Hebrews 5:14](#)). Therefore, the author challenged them to grow into maturity. This was so he could share deeper truths of the faith, instead of repeatedly covering the basics ([6:1-3](#)).

Spiritual maturity does not happen automatically over time. It comes from actively listening to the word of God and living it out with a community of Christians.

Passages for Further Study

[1 Corinthians 2:6](#); [3:1-3](#); [14:20](#); [2 Corinthians 13:9-11](#); [Ephesians 4:11-16](#); [Colossians 4:12](#); [Hebrews 5:11-14](#); [6:1-3](#); [10:14](#); [12:1-2](#); [1 Peter 2:1-3](#)

Spiritual Renewal in the Later Prophets

The prophet Haggai commanded his audience to think about how failing to pay attention to their relationship with God affected their current situation ([Haggai 1:5-7](#); [2:15-18](#)). God sent natural disasters as a warning to encourage repentance ([2:17](#)). Haggai understood that spiritual renewal needed to happen at the same time as rebuilding the temple ([1:12](#)).

The theme of spiritual renewal connects the prophets Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi. They all came after the exile to Babylon. God returned his people to their land, as promised by earlier prophets. Yet, the people needed to focus on their spiritual condition to avoid more problems. The risk of disobeying God during this time shows the need for the Lord's "servant" to come (see [Haggai 2:23](#)).

This servant first referred to Zerubbabel but later became regarded as the Messiah (God's chosen one). A righteous shepherd-king was coming ([Zechariah 9:9](#); see also [Malachi 3:1](#)). God's presence would return in an obvious way. God would restore creation. The worship of the Lord would become universal.

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 30:2-4](#); [Psalm 22:27](#); [Isaiah 11:9-12:6](#); [44:22](#), [26-28](#); [61:6-7](#); [Jeremiah 24:4-7](#); [Amos 4:6-12](#); [Haggai 1:7-15](#); [Zechariah 9:9](#); [14:9](#); [Malachi 3:1](#)

Suffering in Following God

Sometimes, people urge others to accept Jesus Christ because they promise that he will solve their problems. Yet, Jesus did not promise to solve all problems. He often warned people to think about

the cost of following him (see, for example, [Luke 14:28](#)). He also emphasized the difficulties that would come from choosing to follow him (see, for example, [Mark 8:34](#)).

[Exodus 5](#) gives us an example of how following God can sometimes lead to more challenges at first. In the beginning, Pharaoh made the Hebrew people slaves because he was afraid they were becoming too numerous and might cause problems for Egypt ([1:8-22](#)). In chapter [5](#), the situation changes. Moses and Aaron had given the people hope by telling them that God would rescue them ([4:29-31](#)). When Moses and Aaron first met with Pharaoh, they told him that God was the true ruler over all ([5:1-3](#)). As expected, Pharaoh saw this as a challenge to his power as king, and he responded by making life even harder for the Israelites ([5:4-21](#)).

When God's kingdom opposes God's enemies, conflict and suffering often occur for God's people. This should not surprise us. When someone becomes a Christian, they leave behind a life controlled by evil and darkness. They begin a new life guided by God's goodness and light ([Colossians 1:11-14](#)). Those ruling the kingdom of darkness will not let us leave without a fight. We must stand firm in our faith, knowing that God will secure the final victory for us ([Exodus 6:1-8](#); see also [Matthew 5:11-12](#); [John 16:33](#); [Romans 16:20](#); [Ephesians 6:10-18](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 39:6-20](#); [Exodus 5:1-23](#); [18:8](#); [1 Kings 18:3-4](#); [19:1-10](#); [Psalms 6:6-7](#); [22:11-18](#); [Matthew 5:11-12](#); [Mark 8:34](#); [John 15:20](#); [16:33](#); [Romans 16:20](#); [2 Corinthians 11:23-29](#); [Ephesians 6:10-18](#); [2 Timothy 3:12](#); [Hebrews 10:32-36](#); [1 Peter 1:6-7](#); [3:9-17](#); [4:12-19](#)

Symbolic Numbers

Numbers in Scripture have often led people to strange conclusions. Understanding ancient number symbolism can help us interpret the Scriptures better. Yet, this symbolism is not precise. We must be careful when using numbers in interpretation to avoid making unrealistic predictions about the future.

In the Bible, numbers often have special meanings:

- The number *one* can refer to God's unity ([Deuteronomy 6:4](#); [Galatians 3:20](#); [James 2:19](#)).
- *Two* is the minimum number of people needed to provide a valid witness in court ([Deuteronomy 17:6](#); [Revelation 11:3](#)).
- *Three* can imply divine presence ([Genesis 18:1-2](#); [2 Corinthians 13:14](#); [Revelation 1:4-5](#)).
- *Four* can represent the known world. The book of Revelation indicates this with living creatures, horsemen, winds, and angels ([Revelation 4:6-8](#); [6:1-8](#); [7:1](#)). [Genesis 2:10-14](#) indicates this with *four* rivers.
- Adding *three* and *four* to make *seven* represents perfection or divine fulfillment. This shows harmony between God and the world.
- Multiplying *three* by *four* gives *twelve*, the number linked to God's people ([Genesis 35:22-26](#); [Exodus 24:4](#); [28:21](#); [Numbers 17:2](#); [Joshua 4:3-8](#); [1 Kings 18:31](#); [Matthew 10:1-4](#); [19:28](#); [James 1:1](#); [Revelation 12:1](#); [21:12-22:2](#)).
- The number *five* and its multiples, like *ten*, represent human completeness. For example, there are *five* fingers per hand.
- *Six* has a negative meaning, suggesting imperfection. It is neither humanly complete (*five*) nor divinely complete (*seven*).
- Multiples of *ten* represent *many* (for example, *forty*). In contrast, *three sixes* or "666" suggest extreme evil ([Revelation 13:18](#)).

- *One thousand* is the basic large number. The number 12,000 represents a large group of God's people ([Revelation 7:5-8](#)). One hundred and forty-four thousand represents all of God's people ([Revelation 7:4](#); [14:1](#)). The Greek transliteration *myriads* best represents what some translations call "10,000." This is because it is really a huge number, rather than an exact count.

Some numbers in the Bible have symbolic meanings. Yet, it is extremely doubtful to use them to guess when Christ will return or when the world will end. Only God knows these things ([Mark 13:32](#)). God did not intend for the symbolic numbers in Revelation to predict the future. Instead, they explain the importance of the visions.

Translating these numbers into modern sizes, distances, or quantities can sometimes lose their theological meaning. These symbolic numbers can show how a vision relates to the world or to God's people.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 2:2-3; 4:15; 15:13; 41:53-54; Exodus 20:6; 25:31-37; 32:15; Leviticus 16:14; 23:16; 2 Samuel 24:13; 1 Kings 4:26; 17:21; 18:31, 43-44; Job 1:2; Psalm 90:4; Jeremiah 15:3; 49:36; Ezekiel 14:21; Daniel 4:16, 23-25; 7:3, 17, 24; Zechariah 4:2; 6:1; Matthew 10:1-5; 12:40; 18:21-22; Mark 6:7; Luke 15:8; Acts 6:3; 10:16; 1 Corinthians 8:6; Ephesians 4:4-6; 2 Peter 3:8; Revelation 1:16; 2:10; 4:4; 6:1; 7:1, 4-8; 12:1, 3; 13:1; 17:3-14; 20:2-7; 21:12-21](#)